eight kilometres. Hence to approach the Aksai Chin–Lingzithang Plateau from the west, troops would have to ascend this expanse. Unlike in DBO and the Qara Qash, it was almost impossible to find a level piece of ground in the Galwan Valley, even more so in the smaller valleys through which flowed the tributary streams. So inaccessible was the region even from the Chinese side that the PLA had initially left it alone.

Other than a few graziers from the Nubra Valley, all explorers to the Depsang-Aksai Chin-Lingzithang region had stayed away from the Galwan Valley. However, Charlie Company of 1/8 Gorkha Rifles had established a post named Galwan FDL in May-June 1962. Using the few basic tools available and their bare hands, the Gorkhas succeeded in constructing a helipad that became their lifeline. Towards the end of August they had also established Ration Party, a post to the south of Galwan FDL, in the hope of establishing a link with Indian positions in the Shyok River Valley. Towards the north they established two more OPs to keep a watch on Chinese activities at Samzungling, which was the Battalion HQ and the extent of Chinese presence in the area.

By the end of June, 32 Gorkhas left Hot Springs under the command of Captain G. Kotwal, tasked with creating a land link with Ration Party and Galwan FDL from the southern side. On 3 July, having established the Nullah Jn post, Kotwal pushed forward along the Changlung Valley, leaving a JCO and 9 Gorkhas to man Nullah Jn. Two days later, the party established Patrol Base, from where Kotwal sent out reconnaissance parties to find a route that would link him with Ration Party.

Meanwhile, on 6 July 1962, as part of their policy of occupying remote areas and then claiming them as their own, the Chinese sent a patrol into the northern part of the Galwan Valley. To their chagrin and complete surprise, they ran into the Gorkhas who were firmly entrenched there.

Until July 1962, as had been the case with the entire expanse of the Aksai Chin in the 1950s, the Chinese had usually succeeded in entering an unoccupied isolated area and New Delhi had been reduced to sending notes of protest to Peking asserting that the territorial integrity of India had been violated. From the Chinese point of view, the presence of Indian troops in the Galwan Valley created a serious problem that required some deft footwork, even if reality had nothing to do with Chinese claims. Accordingly, on 8 July, Peking sent a protest note to New Delhi claiming